DARKHAN MENTOR | RESEARCH REPORT SERIES

How to Write a Business Report: Structure and Style

A Research Report

This report explains, step by step, how to plan, research, structure and write a clear, professional business report. It covers the standard structure used in workplaces and universities, the main types of report, methods for gathering evidence, ways of presenting data, analytical tools such as SWOT analysis, and the writing style that makes a report easy to read and easy to act on. A complete worked example and a final checklist are included so that a reader can move directly from reading this report to writing one of their own.

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Abstract

A business report is a formal document that presents information, analysis and recommendations so that a reader — usually a manager, a client, a committee or a teacher — can understand a situation and make a decision. Unlike an essay, which argues a point, or a memo, which gives a short instruction, a report is built around evidence: facts are gathered, organised under clear headings, shown in tables and charts where numbers help, analysed, and then turned into conclusions and practical recommendations. This report explains that whole process. It begins by defining a business report and describing its readers, then classifies the main types — informational, analytical, feasibility, progress and annual reports — and explains when each one is appropriate. It then sets out the standard structure, from the title page and executive summary through the introduction, methodology, findings and analysis to conclusions, recommendations and appendices. Separate chapters show how to write an executive summary that a busy reader can use on its own, how to choose and describe research methods honestly, and how to present findings so that tables and charts support the text instead of replacing it. The analysis chapter demonstrates SWOT analysis, market research and basic financial interpretation through a worked example based on a fictional small shop, clearly labelled as invented for teaching purposes. Later chapters deal with conclusions and recommendations, with clear, concise professional style, and with a complete worked outline for a short market-research report. The report closes with the most common mistakes — vague aims, unsupported claims, overloaded tables, inconsistent formatting and recommendations that nobody could actually carry out — and a final checklist that a writer can use before submitting any report. The guidance is general and practical: it applies to school and university assignments, to small-business reports, and to workplace reporting alike.

Keywords: business report; executive summary; report structure; SWOT analysis; market research; business writing; recommendations.

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How to use this report: Chapters 1 to 3 give the foundations. Chapters 4 to 8 follow the order in which a report is actually written and read. Chapters 9 to 11 are practical tools — style rules, a worked example and a checklist. A reader in a hurry can read the Abstract, Chapter 4 and Chapter 11 and still write a sound report; a reader who wants the full method should work through the chapters in order.

Chapter 1: Introduction — What a Business Report Is and Who Reads It

A business report is a structured, evidence-based document written to help someone make a decision, understand a problem, or check progress. It is one of the most common forms of writing in working life. Managers ask for reports before they approve spending, open a new branch, change a price, or launch a product. Banks ask for reports before they lend money. Teachers and examiners ask for reports because writing one proves that a student can find information, judge it, organise it and explain it clearly. In every case the report exists for the reader, not for the writer. Its success is measured by a simple test: after reading it, does the reader know what happened, what it means, and what should happen next?

A report is different from other kinds of business writing in several important ways. An essay develops an argument and is judged on the quality of its reasoning. A letter

or an email is usually short, personal and written to one person. A memo gives an instruction or a brief update. A report is longer, more formal and more systematic than any of these. It states its purpose at the start, shows where its information came from, presents findings in a logical order, separates facts from interpretation, and ends with conclusions and recommendations that follow from the evidence. A good report can be read at two speeds: a busy reader can read the executive summary and the recommendations and understand the whole message in five minutes, while a careful reader can work through the findings and the analysis and check every claim.

1.1 Who Reads a Business Report?

Before writing a single word, a report writer must ask: who will read this, and what do they need from it? The answer shapes everything — the length, the level of detail, the technical language and even the choice of charts. A report written for a shop owner who left school at sixteen must use plain language and explain every technical term. A report written for a bank manager must emphasise financial figures, risk and repayment. A report written for a university teacher must show sources, method and critical thinking. The most common readers are senior managers, who want a clear recommendation and the evidence behind it; colleagues and team members, who need accurate facts to do their own jobs; clients and customers, who want to know that a supplier is reliable and professional; investors and lenders, who want to judge whether a business is sound; and examiners, who want to see that a student has followed a proper method.

A useful habit is to write a one-sentence description of the reader before starting. For example: 'The reader is the owner of a small clothing shop who wants to decide whether to open a second shop, and who has thirty minutes to read this report.' That sentence tells the writer what to include and what to leave out. It also prevents the most common fault in student and workplace reports alike: writing to impress the reader with long words and long sentences, instead of writing to help the reader decide.

1.2 The Purpose of a Report

Every report has a purpose, and the purpose should be written down in one or two sentences before any research begins. The purpose is often set by the person who commissions the report, in a brief or a terms-of-reference statement. A typical brief might read: 'Investigate whether our delivery service is meeting customer expectations, and recommend improvements.' That brief contains two tasks — investigate, and recommend — and the report must do both. If the writer only describes the delivery service without recommending anything, the report is incomplete. If the writer recommends changes without first showing evidence, the recommendations carry no weight. A clear purpose also protects the writer from the temptation to include interesting but irrelevant material. Every paragraph should be tested against the purpose: does this help the reader reach the decision the report

exists to support? If not, it should be cut.

1.3 What Makes a Good Report?

Good reports share five qualities. First, they are accurate: every fact can be checked, every figure is correct, and every source is named. Second, they are clear: headings guide the reader, sentences are short, and technical terms are explained. Third, they are objective: the writer separates what was found from what the writer thinks it means, and reports unwelcome findings honestly. A report that hides bad news is worse than useless, because decisions based on it will be wrong. Fourth, they are complete: they answer the question that was asked, cover all the important evidence, and say plainly where information was not available. Fifth, they are practical: conclusions follow from the findings, and recommendations name a specific action, a responsible person and a time frame wherever possible. The rest of this report shows how each of these qualities is achieved in practice.

Chapter 2: Types of Business Reports

Business reports are classified in several ways — by purpose, by how often they are produced, and by who reads them. The classification matters because each type has a different shape. A progress report that is mostly a list of completed tasks would be a poor feasibility study, and an annual report that reads like a research paper would confuse shareholders. This chapter describes the five types a student or a small-business writer is most likely to meet, with a short example of each.

2.1 Informational Reports

An informational report presents facts without analysis or recommendations. Its job is to tell the reader what is happening. Examples include a monthly sales summary, a stock report, a report on staff attendance, or a summary of customer complaints received in a quarter. The structure is simple: a brief introduction stating what the report covers, the findings presented in a logical order, often with tables, and a short closing summary. There is no analysis chapter and no recommendation, because the reader has not asked the writer to judge the facts, only to present them accurately. The danger with informational reports is that they become mere lists of numbers. Even here, the writer should organise the facts, highlight the most important ones, and make sure the reader can see patterns — for example, that complaints rose sharply in one month, or that one product accounts for half of all sales.

2.2 Analytical Reports

An analytical report goes further: it presents facts, interprets them, and draws conclusions. Most of the reports discussed in this guide are analytical. A typical example is a report on falling sales: it would show the sales figures, compare them with previous years and with competitors, look for causes such as price changes, new competitors or poor service, and conclude with an explanation of why sales fell.

Analytical reports are longer than informational reports and need a methodology section, because the reader must be able to judge whether the analysis is trustworthy. The writer must be careful to separate findings from analysis — first, what the figures show; then, what the writer thinks they mean. Mixing the two makes it hard for the reader to check the reasoning.

2.3 Feasibility Reports

A feasibility report answers one question: should we do this? It is written before a decision is taken — before opening a new shop, launching a product, buying expensive equipment, or entering a new market. The report examines the idea from several angles: is there a market, what will it cost, what income can it earn, what are the risks, and are there legal or practical obstacles? It usually ends with a clear recommendation: proceed, proceed with changes, or do not proceed. Because money is at stake, feasibility reports must be honest about uncertainty. A report that only lists the advantages of an idea is not a feasibility study; it is a sales pitch. A good feasibility report gives the strongest arguments against the idea as well as for it, and shows the figures on which the judgement rests.

2.4 Progress Reports

A progress report is written at intervals during a project — weekly, monthly, or at set milestones — to tell managers or clients what has been done, what remains, what problems have arisen, and whether the project is on time and within budget. Progress reports are usually short and use a standard format so that successive reports can be compared. A typical format is: work completed since the last report; work planned for the next period; problems and delays, with their causes; spending so far against the budget; and any decisions needed from the reader. The most important quality of a progress report is honesty about delays. A problem reported early can be fixed; a problem hidden until the deadline is a crisis.

2.5 Annual Reports

An annual report is published once a year by a company or an organisation to tell shareholders, members and the public how it has performed. It usually contains a statement from the chairperson or chief executive, a review of the year's activities, financial statements (profit and loss, balance sheet and cash flow), and plans for the coming year. Annual reports are the most formal type of report and are often professionally designed and printed, but their purpose is the same as any other report: to give the reader a true and fair picture, including difficulties as well as successes. For a student, reading a real annual report — many are freely available on company websites — is an excellent way to see professional report writing in practice.

Type	Main question	Ends with
Informational	What is happening?	Summary of facts
Analytical	What does it mean?	Conclusions

Type	Main question	Ends with
Feasibility	Should we do it?	Recommendation to proceed or not
Progress	How far have we got?	Next steps and decisions needed
Annual	How did we perform this year?	Financial statements and plans

Some reports combine types. A market-research report, for example, is both informational (it presents survey results) and analytical (it interprets them). A business plan contains a feasibility study and an analytical section. The writer should not worry about labelling the report perfectly; what matters is choosing the structure that fits the reader's question, and then following it consistently.

Chapter 3: The Standard Structure: Title Page, Executive Summary, Contents, Introduction

Although reports differ in subject and length, most follow the same standard structure. Learning this structure once means that a writer can approach any report with confidence, and that a reader can find information quickly because they know where to look. The structure has two parts: the front matter, which comes before the main text, and the main body, which carries the argument. This chapter explains the front matter and the introduction; later chapters deal with each later section in detail.

3.1 Title Page

The title page is the first thing the reader sees, and it should answer four questions at a glance: what is this report about, who wrote it, for whom was it written, and when? A good title is specific. 'Report' is not a title. 'Business Report' is barely better. 'A Feasibility Study for Opening a Second Branch of Al-Noor Bookshop in Faisalabad' tells the reader the subject, the type of report and the place in a single line. Below the title come the writer's name (and, for a student, the course and institution), the name of the person or organisation the report was written for, and the date. The title page should be clean and uncluttered: a title, a subtitle if needed, the names and the date, and nothing else. Decoration, pictures and coloured borders are not needed and usually make a report look less professional, not more.

3.2 Executive Summary

The executive summary — sometimes called the synopsis — is a short summary of the whole report, usually between half a page and two pages long. It is placed immediately after the title page because many readers, especially senior managers, will read only this section. Chapter 4 explains how to write it in detail. The key point here is that it is written last, after the rest of the report is finished, even though it appears near the front. A summary written first can only guess at the conclusions; a summary written last can state them accurately.

3.3 Contents Page

The contents page lists every chapter and major heading, with the page number on which it begins, and also lists tables, figures and appendices if there are many of them. It is generated after the report is finished and page numbers are final. In a short report of fewer than ten pages a contents page is optional; in anything longer it is expected. A contents page also serves the writer: if the headings listed there do not tell a clear story in order, the structure of the report probably needs rearranging before submission.

3.4 Introduction

The introduction is the first chapter of the main body. It has four jobs, and a good introduction does all four in a page or two. First, it gives background: the situation that led to the report, in enough detail for a reader who knows nothing about the subject. Second, it states the purpose of the report and the question it answers. Third, it states the scope — what the report covers and, equally important, what it does not cover. A report on customer satisfaction in one shop, for example, does not cover the whole retail industry, and the writer should say so. Fourth, it gives a brief outline of how the report is organised, so the reader knows what to expect. The introduction should not contain findings or conclusions. Its job is to prepare the reader, not to give away the results.

3.5 The Rest of the Report at a Glance

1. Methodology — how the information was gathered (Chapter 5).
2. Findings — what was found, presented in order (Chapter 6).
3. Analysis — what the findings mean (Chapter 7).
4. Conclusions — the answers to the report's questions (Chapter 8).
5. Recommendations — what should be done, by whom and by when (Chapter 8).
6. References and appendices — sources, questionnaires, raw data and detailed tables (end of the report).

Appendices deserve a short note here. An appendix holds material that supports the report but would interrupt the reader if placed in the main text: a copy of the questionnaire used, a full table of raw figures, a sample interview transcript, or a detailed calculation. Each appendix is labelled (Appendix A, Appendix B) and mentioned in the main text at the point where it is relevant — 'The full questionnaire is given in Appendix A.' Material that is never referred to in the text should not be in an appendix at all.

Chapter 4: Writing the Executive Summary

The executive summary is the most-read part of any report, and often the only part a senior manager reads. It must therefore work on its own: a reader who reads nothing else should still understand the purpose of the report, the main findings, the conclusions and the recommendations. Writing a good executive summary is a skill in

itself, and it is worth spending real time on it — many reports have failed not because the research was poor, but because the summary did not persuade a busy reader to take the findings seriously.

4.1 What to Include — and What to Leave Out

A good executive summary contains five elements, in this order. First, one or two sentences of background and purpose: why the report was written and what question it answers. Second, a brief note on method: how the information was gathered, in one or two sentences — for example, 'A survey of 120 customers was carried out in March, together with interviews with five members of staff.' Third, the main findings, reduced to the three or four most important points, with the key figures. Fourth, the conclusions that follow from those findings. Fifth, the recommendations. What the summary must not contain is new information that does not appear in the main report, detailed tables, long explanations of method, or background that belongs in the introduction. It is a summary, not a second report.

4.2 Length and Tone

As a guide, the executive summary should be about five to ten per cent of the length of the whole report: roughly one page for a ten-page report, and no more than two pages for a twenty-page report. It is written in the same formal, plain style as the rest of the report, in the past tense for what was done and found ('The survey found that...'), and in the present tense for conclusions that still hold ('Customers value...'). It should not begin with phrases such as 'This report is about...' repeated from the introduction; it should go straight to the point. Each sentence should carry information. A useful test is to read the summary aloud and ask after every sentence, 'Would a manager need to know this before deciding?' If the answer is no, the sentence should be cut.

4.3 A Worked Example

The paragraph below is an example of an executive summary for a short fictional report. The business is invented, and the figures are illustrative only. Notice how much information is packed into a short space, and how each sentence earns its place.

Example — Executive summary (fictional): 'This report investigates falling sales at Ravi General Store, a small grocery shop in Lahore, and recommends actions to restore them. Sales fell by 18 per cent between January and June 2026. A survey of 100 customers and an analysis of till records were carried out in July 2026. The survey found that 42 per cent of customers had started shopping at a new supermarket 500 metres away, that prices at Ravi General Store were on average 9 per cent higher than at the supermarket, and that 61 per cent of customers rated the shop's opening hours as inconvenient. The report concludes that price and opening hours, rather than the quality of goods, are the main causes of the fall in sales. It recommends that the shop reduce prices on the twenty most-bought items to match

the supermarket, extend opening hours to 10 p.m., and introduce a weekly discount day. Together these steps are estimated to cost Rs 45,000 in the first month and to recover the lost sales within three months.'

That summary is about 170 words. A reader who reads only those words knows the problem, the method, the three main findings, the conclusion and the recommendation, including the cost and the expected time to recover. The rest of the report exists to prove that every claim in the summary is true.

4.4 Common Faults in Executive Summaries

- Too long — a summary that runs to four pages is not a summary; cut it to the essential findings and recommendations.
- Too vague — 'Sales have fallen and some improvements are needed' tells the reader nothing. Give figures and name the actions.
- New material — a finding or a recommendation that appears only in the summary, and nowhere in the report, cannot be trusted and should not be there.
- Written first — a summary drafted before the analysis is finished almost always misstates the conclusions. Always write it last.

Chapter 5: Methodology: How the Information Was Gathered

The methodology chapter explains how the writer obtained the information in the report. Its purpose is to let the reader judge whether the findings can be trusted. A report that states findings without saying how they were obtained asks the reader to take everything on trust; a report with a clear methodology lets the reader check the work. In a short student report this chapter may be only a page long. In a longer research report it may run to several pages. In either case it must be honest, specific and complete enough for another person to repeat the work.

5.1 Primary and Secondary Sources

Information comes from two kinds of source. Primary sources are information the writer gathers directly for this report: surveys, interviews, observations, experiments, or figures from the organisation's own records. Secondary sources are information gathered by someone else and already published: books, journal articles, government statistics, trade reports, company annual reports and reputable websites. Most business reports use both. A report on customer satisfaction, for example, might use a customer survey (primary) and published figures on shopping habits in the country (secondary). The methodology should list both kinds and say how each was used. Secondary sources must be cited properly, with enough detail for the reader to find them.

5.2 Surveys and Questionnaires

A survey asks the same questions of a number of people and counts the answers. Good survey questions are short, clear and neutral. A leading question such as 'Do you agree that our service is excellent?' pushes the respondent towards one answer and produces useless data. A neutral question — 'How would you rate our service: excellent, good, fair or poor?' — lets the respondent answer honestly. Questions should ask about one thing at a time; 'Was the shop clean and the staff friendly?' is two questions, and a respondent who thought the shop was clean but the staff unfriendly would not know how to answer. The methodology should state how many people were surveyed, how they were chosen, when the survey was carried out, and how many replied. A survey of 100 customers chosen at random on different days of the week is far more reliable than a survey of 20 friends of the owner on a single afternoon, and the reader needs to know which one it was.

5.3 Interviews and Observation

Interviews give deeper information than surveys, because the interviewer can ask follow-up questions and listen to the respondent's reasons. They are usually used with a small number of people — managers, long-standing customers, suppliers — and the methodology should say who was interviewed, for how long, and whether the interviews were structured (the same questions for everyone) or semi-structured (a list of topics, with freedom to follow interesting answers). Observation means watching what actually happens: counting how many customers enter a shop in an hour, timing how long they wait at the till, or noting which shelves they look at. Observation is useful because what people do is often different from what they say they do, but it must be recorded systematically, with times, dates and counts, or it is only anecdote.

5.4 Sampling, Limitations and Ethics

It is rarely possible to ask everyone, so a report uses a sample — a smaller group chosen to represent the whole. The methodology should explain how the sample was chosen and admit its limits. A sample of customers surveyed only on weekday mornings will miss evening and weekend shoppers, and the report should say so. Limitations are not a weakness in a report; hiding them is. A writer who states the limits honestly helps the reader judge how far the findings can be generalised. Ethics matter too: survey respondents should be told why the survey is being done, their answers should be kept confidential, and nobody should be pressured to take part. If a business's own records were used, the methodology should say that permission was obtained. A short paragraph on limitations and ethics, placed at the end of the methodology chapter, is a mark of a professional report.

Chapter 6: Findings: Presenting Data with Tables and Charts

The findings chapter presents what was discovered, in a logical order, without interpretation. Interpretation belongs in the analysis chapter. This separation is important: if findings and opinion are mixed together, the reader cannot tell which statements are facts and which are the writer's judgement. A good findings chapter is organised by the questions the report set out to answer, or by theme, with a clear heading for each section. Each section should begin with a sentence that tells the reader what the section is about, then present the evidence, then move on. The evidence may be given in words, in tables or in charts; usually a combination is best.

6.1 Writing Findings in Words

Text is best for explaining, comparing and giving context. Numbers in text should be used sparingly and rounded sensibly: 'about two in five customers (42 per cent)' reads better than a string of exact decimals, and the exact figure can be given in the table that follows. Every factual claim in the findings should be traceable to a source — a survey result, a company record, or a published statistic — and the source should be named or numbered so the reader can check it. A common fault is to present opinions gathered in a survey as if they were facts about the world. 'Sixty-one per cent of customers said the opening hours were inconvenient' is a finding. 'The opening hours are inconvenient' is an interpretation, and it belongs in the analysis chapter.

6.2 Tables

A table is the best way to present exact figures that the reader may want to look up. A good table has a number and a title ('Table 1: Monthly sales, January–June 2026'), clear column headings with units (Rs, per cent, number of customers), and figures aligned so that they are easy to compare. Tables should not be overloaded: a table with twelve columns and forty rows will not be read. If the data is large, put the full table in an appendix and a short summary table in the findings chapter. Every table in the report must be mentioned in the text — 'Table 1 shows that sales fell in every month from February onwards' — and the text should draw attention to the important pattern in the table, not simply repeat every number in it. The table below is a sample findings table for the fictional Ravi General Store example used in Chapter 4. The figures are invented for teaching purposes.

Month (2026)	Sales (Rs)	Customers	Change vs Jan
January	850,000	4,200	—
February	810,000	4,050	-4.7%
March	760,000	3,800	-10.6%
April	720,000	3,550	-15.3%
May	705,000	3,480	-17.1%

Month (2026)	Sales (Rs)	Customers	Change vs Jan
June	697,000	3,410	-18.0%

Table 1: Monthly sales and customer numbers at Ravi General Store, January–June 2026 (fictional figures for illustration). The table shows a steady fall in both sales and customer numbers over six months, with the largest single fall between February and March. The text of the findings chapter would also report the survey results that help explain this pattern — for example, that the new supermarket opened in March — but the explanation itself, and the judgement that the supermarket is the main cause, belongs in the analysis chapter, not here.

6.3 Charts

A chart is best for showing a pattern, a trend or a comparison at a glance. A line chart shows change over time, such as monthly sales. A bar chart compares quantities, such as sales of different products or satisfaction ratings. A pie chart shows parts of a whole, such as the share of sales from each product group, but it should be used only when there are few categories; a pie chart with ten slices is unreadable. Every chart needs a number and a title, labelled axes with units, and a source note. Charts should be used only where they add something: a chart that repeats a small table adds nothing, and a chart chosen for decoration rather than clarity makes a report look amateur. As a rule, if the pattern can be stated in one sentence, state it in words; if the reader needs to see the shape of the data, use a chart. In this report the sales trend in Table 1 would be shown as a line chart in a real report, with months on the horizontal axis and sales in rupees on the vertical axis, so that the steady downward slope is visible immediately.

6.4 Ordering the Findings

Findings should be presented in the order that makes the story easiest to follow, which is usually the order of the report's questions, or from the most important finding to the least important. Within each section, move from the general to the specific: first the overall picture, then the detail. Use headings and subheadings generously, number tables and figures in the order in which they appear, and check that every table and figure is referred to in the text. Before moving to the analysis chapter, re-read the findings and ask: could a reader who disagrees with my conclusions still accept these findings as accurate? If the answer is yes, the chapter has done its job.

Chapter 7: Analysis: SWOT, Market Research and Financial Interpretation

Analysis is the chapter where the writer stops reporting what was found and starts explaining what it means. It is the most difficult part of a report and the part that most clearly shows the writer's judgement. Good analysis does three things: it looks

for patterns and causes in the findings, it tests those explanations against other evidence, and it weighs the evidence honestly, including evidence that points the other way. This chapter explains three tools that are used in almost every business analysis: SWOT analysis, market research, and basic financial interpretation.

7.1 SWOT Analysis

SWOT analysis organises the position of a business under four headings: Strengths and Weaknesses, which are internal to the business, and Opportunities and Threats, which come from outside it. Strengths are things the business does well — loyal customers, a good location, skilled staff, low costs. Weaknesses are internal problems — high prices, short opening hours, old equipment, dependence on one supplier. Opportunities are favourable conditions outside the business — a growing local population, a competitor closing, a new housing estate nearby. Threats are external dangers — a new competitor, rising costs, a change in the law, a recession. The value of SWOT is not in listing items; it is in the connections between them. A strength can be used to take an opportunity; a weakness must be fixed before a threat can be met. A good SWOT analysis therefore ends not with four lists, but with two or three conclusions about what the business should do.

7.2 A Worked SWOT Example (Fictional)

The table below is a SWOT analysis for Ravi General Store, the fictional small grocery shop used as an example in this report. The business, the figures and the situation are entirely invented for teaching purposes and do not describe any real shop. The example is included so that a reader can see how a SWOT analysis is set out and how it leads to action.

	Helpful	**Harmful**
Internal	STRENGTHS: Loyal older customers; central location; owner knows customers by name; no debt	WEAKNESSES: Prices 9% above supermarket; closes at 8 p.m.; narrow range; no home delivery
External	OPPORTUNITIES: New flats being built nearby (300 homes); demand for home delivery; local produce popular	THREATS: Supermarket 500 m away; rising wholesale prices; customers moving to online shopping

Reading the four boxes together gives the analysis. The shop's strengths — loyal customers and a central location — are real, but they are being undermined by a clear weakness (higher prices and short hours) and a direct threat (the new supermarket). The opportunities point to a way forward: the new flats will bring new customers who value a nearby shop, and home delivery would use the shop's local knowledge to compete where the supermarket is less personal. The conclusion that follows is not 'the shop is in trouble' — it is that the shop must compete on convenience and service rather than on price alone, by extending hours, adding delivery, and matching the supermarket on the twenty most-bought items. That is the difference between a list and an analysis.

7.3 Market Research

Market research means finding out about the people who might buy a product or use a service: who they are, what they want, what they currently buy, and what they would pay. It has two parts. Primary market research is gathered for the report itself, usually by survey, interview or observation, as described in Chapter 5. Secondary market research uses published information: population figures, income levels, competitors' prices, and reports on shopping habits. A small business rarely needs expensive research; a well-designed survey of 100 customers, a count of people passing the shop, and a careful comparison of five competitors' prices will usually give enough information to decide. The analysis chapter should compare the findings with the market: is the business's price high or low compared with competitors? Is its range wider or narrower? Are its customers typical of the area, or a particular group? The answers to those questions, stated plainly, are the analysis.

7.4 Financial Interpretation

A business report often needs to interpret simple financial figures, and the writer does not need to be an accountant to do it well. Four ideas cover most cases. Revenue is the money coming in from sales. Costs are what the business spends — stock, wages, rent, electricity. Profit is revenue minus costs, and it is profit, not revenue, that decides whether a business survives. A shop can have high sales and still make a loss if its costs are higher. Second, trends matter more than single figures: sales falling by 18 per cent over six months is a pattern that needs action, while a single bad month may be a one-off event. Third, comparisons give meaning: a profit margin of 10 per cent means little on its own, but it means a great deal if competitors average 15 per cent. Finally, a recommendation that costs money should always be compared with the money it is expected to save or earn. In the Ravi General Store example, the recommended price cuts and longer hours were estimated to cost Rs 45,000 in the first month and to recover the lost sales within three months. That comparison — cost against expected benefit — is what lets a reader judge whether a recommendation is worth following. Where exact figures are not available, the writer should say so and give a range or an estimate, clearly labelled as such, rather than inventing a precise number.

Chapter 8: Conclusions and Recommendations

Conclusions and recommendations are often placed together in one chapter, but they are different things and must not be confused. A conclusion is a judgement that follows from the findings and the analysis: it answers the question the report was asked. A recommendation is an action that should be taken because of that conclusion. The link between them should be visible: each recommendation should follow from a conclusion, and each conclusion should be supported by evidence presented earlier. A recommendation that appears from nowhere, with no conclusion and no evidence behind it, will not be followed.

8.1 Writing Conclusions

Conclusions should be short, specific and directly tied to the purpose of the report. It helps to number them and to write each one as a complete sentence. For example: '1. The fall in sales at Ravi General Store was caused mainly by higher prices and shorter opening hours than the new supermarket, not by the quality of the goods.' That conclusion can be checked: the findings chapter shows the price comparison and the survey results on opening hours, and the analysis chapter explains why those two factors, rather than quality, explain the fall. A conclusion should not introduce new evidence, repeat the findings at length, or go beyond what the evidence supports. If the survey covered only one shop in one town, the conclusion should be about that shop, not about retailing in the whole country. Where the evidence is uncertain, the conclusion should say so: 'The evidence suggests...' is honest; 'This proves...' is usually an overstatement.

8.2 Writing Recommendations

A recommendation is useful only if someone can act on it. The SMART test is a helpful check: is the recommendation Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound? 'Improve customer service' fails the test — it does not say what to do, how success will be recognised, or by when. 'Extend opening hours to 10 p.m. from 1 August, and review the effect on evening sales after one month' passes it: the action is named, the date is given, and the way of measuring success is stated. Each recommendation should also name who is responsible, give an idea of cost where money is involved, and be listed in order of priority. It is better to make three recommendations that can all be carried out than ten that cannot. A short table is often the clearest way to present recommendations.

No.	Recommendation	Who	By when
R1	Match supermarket prices on 20 most-bought items	Owner	1 Aug 2026
R2	Extend opening hours to 10 p.m. daily	Owner + staff	1 Aug 2026
R3	Start home delivery within 2 km (phone orders)	Owner	1 Sep 2026
R4	Weekly discount day (10% off on Wednesdays)	Owner	15 Aug 2026

A final point: recommendations should be realistic for the reader. A recommendation that a small shop spend money it does not have, or hire staff it cannot afford, will be ignored, however good the analysis behind it. If the ideal action is not affordable, the report should say so and recommend the best affordable alternative, with the cost stated plainly.

Chapter 9: Writing Style: Clear, Concise and Professional

The style of a business report is plain, formal and direct. Its aim is to be understood quickly by a busy reader, not to impress the reader with the writer's vocabulary. Many reports fail because their style gets in the way of their content: long sentences, vague words, unnecessary jargon and inconsistent formatting all make a report harder to read and less persuasive. This chapter sets out the style rules that matter most.

9.1 Clear Sentences

Write short sentences. A good guide is an average of fifteen to twenty words per sentence, with no sentence longer than about thirty words. One idea per sentence is enough. If a sentence has to be read twice to be understood, rewrite it. Prefer the active voice, which names who does what: 'The survey found that prices were too high' is clearer than 'It was found by the survey that prices were too high.' Prefer concrete words to abstract ones: 'sales fell by 18 per cent' is better than 'there was a significant deterioration in the sales situation.' Avoid jargon unless the reader will certainly understand it, and explain any technical term the first time it is used. A report is not the place for slang, jokes, or emotional language; the facts should carry the force of the argument.

9.2 Concise Writing

Conciseness means using no more words than the meaning needs. It is not the same as leaving out information. Cut filler phrases: 'due to the fact that' becomes 'because'; 'in order to' becomes 'to'; 'at this point in time' becomes 'now'. Cut repetition: if a point has been made in the findings, do not make it again in the same words in the analysis — refer back to it instead. Cut empty intensifiers: 'very', 'really', 'extremely' and 'highly' add emphasis without adding information, and a report that uses them on every page soon sounds exaggerated. A practical method is to finish a draft, leave it for a day, and then read it with a pen, crossing out every word that can be removed without changing the meaning. Most first drafts can lose ten per cent of their words and become clearer as a result.

9.3 Professional Tone, Headings and Formatting

The tone of a report should be neutral and respectful, even when the findings are unwelcome. 'The delivery service failed to meet its target on 14 days in June' is professional. 'The delivery service was a disaster' is not. The writer should avoid the first person ('I think...') in most reports; the impersonal style ('The evidence shows...') keeps the focus on the facts. Headings are part of the style: they should be parallel in form, numbered consistently, and informative — 'Falling Sales, January–June 2026' is a better heading than 'Sales'. Formatting should be consistent throughout: one font for the body, one for headings, the same spacing, the same style of table, and page

numbers on every page after the title page. A report that changes font, spacing or heading style from chapter to chapter looks unfinished, however good its content. Finally, numbers and units must be consistent: choose one currency, one date format and one way of writing percentages, and use them throughout.

9.4 Before-and-After Examples

Weak: 'It is the opinion of the writer that, due to the fact that a very large number of customers were extremely unhappy with the level of service, it would be a good idea for the management to think about making some improvements in the near future.' Strong: 'Sixty-one per cent of customers rated the service as poor. The shop should extend its opening hours to 10 p.m. from 1 August.' The strong version is shorter, gives a figure, names the action and gives a date. That is the standard to aim for in every paragraph of a report.

Weak: 'Sales went down a lot.' Strong: 'Sales fell by 18 per cent, from Rs 850,000 in January to Rs 697,000 in June 2026.' The strong version gives the size of the change, the figures, and the period — everything a reader needs to judge how serious the fall is. Vague words such as 'a lot', 'many', 'some' and 'soon' should be replaced by numbers and dates wherever the information is available.

Chapter 10: A Complete Worked Example: A Short Market-Research Report

This chapter brings the guidance together by setting out a complete outline for a short market-research report for a fictional business. The business is invented, and the outline is a model a reader can adapt to a real subject. The report is imagined as ten to twelve pages long, written for the owner of a small business who must decide whether to launch a new product.

10.1 The Situation and the Brief

Fictional brief: 'Ayesha's Bakery is a small bakery in Multan that sells bread, cakes and biscuits. The owner, Ayesha, wants to know whether to start selling sugar-free cakes for customers with diabetes and for customers who want to eat less sugar. She has asked for a report that answers three questions: Is there demand for sugar-free cakes in her area? What price would customers pay? Who are the competitors, and what do they charge? The report should be ready in three weeks and should end with a clear recommendation.' The brief is a good one: it names the decision, lists the questions, and sets a deadline. A writer who received a vaguer brief — 'Look into sugar-free cakes' — should ask for the questions and the deadline before starting.

10.2 Outline of the Report

1. Title page — 'Sugar-Free Cakes in Multan: A Market-Research Report for Ayesha's Bakery', writer's name, date.
2. Executive summary (1 page) — demand, price, competition, recommendation

in brief.

3. Contents page.

4. Introduction — background on the bakery, the three questions, scope (one town, three weeks), outline of the report.

5. Methodology — survey of 80 customers in the shop over two weeks; price check at 6 competing bakeries; published health statistics on diabetes in Pakistan (secondary source); limitations (small sample, one town).

6. Findings — (a) survey results: how many customers want sugar-free cakes, how often they would buy, what price they would pay (table); (b) competitors: prices and ranges (table); (c) market size: number of people with diabetes in the district (published figures).

7. Analysis — SWOT for launching sugar-free cakes; comparison of Ayesha's prices with competitors; estimate of weekly revenue if 30 cakes sell at Rs 600 each; risks (cost of sugar substitutes, short shelf life).

8. Conclusions — numbered answers to the three questions.

9. Recommendations — launch with three flavours, price Rs 600, trial for two months, review after eight weeks; named person and dates for each step.

10. References and appendices — questionnaire (Appendix A), full survey table (Appendix B), competitor price list (Appendix C).

10.3 What the Analysis Would Show

Suppose the survey found that 35 of the 80 customers asked (44 per cent) would buy a sugar-free cake at least once a month, that most would pay between Rs 500 and Rs 700, and that none of the six competing bakeries sold sugar-free cakes. Suppose the published figures showed a high and rising number of people with diabetes in the district. The analysis would then be straightforward: there is demand, there is no direct competition, and the price customers will pay covers the extra cost of sugar substitutes with a reasonable margin. The SWOT would list the bakery's reputation for quality as a strength, the higher ingredient cost as a weakness, the unserved demand as an opportunity, and the possibility that a larger bakery copies the idea as a threat. The recommendation would be to launch on a trial basis, with a review date, rather than committing to a full range at once. The point of the example is the chain of reasoning: brief, method, findings, analysis, conclusion, recommendation — each step following from the one before it, and each claim traceable to evidence. A report built in that order is easy to check, easy to trust, and easy to act on.

Chapter 11: Common Mistakes and a Final Checklist

Most reports that fail do so for a small number of avoidable reasons. This chapter lists the mistakes that appear most often in student and workplace reports, and then gives a checklist that a writer can work through before submitting any report. The checklist is deliberately practical: each item can be checked in a few minutes, and a report that passes every item is unlikely to contain a serious fault.

11.1 Common Mistakes

- No clear purpose — the report describes a topic instead of answering a question. Fix it by writing the purpose in one sentence before starting, and testing every paragraph against it.
- Findings and opinion mixed together — the reader cannot tell what was found from what the writer thinks. Fix it by keeping findings and analysis in separate chapters.
- Unsupported claims — statements such as 'customers are unhappy' with no survey, figure or source behind them. Fix it by giving the evidence for every important claim, or by removing the claim.
- Overloaded tables and charts — tables with too many columns, charts with too many slices, figures with no titles or units. Fix it by putting detail in an appendix and keeping a short summary table in the text.
- Recommendations nobody can carry out — vague, expensive or undated. Fix them with the SMART test: specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound, with a named person responsible.
- Inconsistent formatting — different fonts, heading styles, date formats and page numbers that change through the report. Fix it by setting the format before writing and checking it at the end.
- Poor proofreading — spelling errors, wrong figures, and tables whose totals do not add up. Fix it by reading the report aloud, checking every figure against its source, and asking another person to read it if possible.
- Plagiarism and missing references — copying text or figures from a source without acknowledgement. Fix it by noting every source as it is used and listing all sources at the end. Even a short report must name its sources.

11.2 Final Checklist

Work through this checklist when the report is complete, and do not submit it until every item can be ticked honestly.

[ ] The title page gives the title, writer, reader and date.

[ ] The executive summary is one to two pages, written last, and contains purpose, method, main findings, conclusions and recommendations.

[ ] The contents page lists every chapter with the correct page number.

[ ] The introduction states the purpose, the questions and the scope.

[ ] The methodology says how information was gathered, from whom, and when — and states its limitations.

[ ] Findings are presented in order, with every table and chart numbered, titled and mentioned in the text.

[ ] Analysis is kept separate from findings, and every conclusion follows from the evidence.

[ ] Recommendations are specific, dated, costed where money is involved, and name who is responsible.

[ ] Every figure has been checked against its source; table totals add up.

[ ] Sources are cited in the text and listed at the end; no material is copied without acknowledgement.

[ ] The style is clear and concise: short sentences, active voice, no jargon without explanation.

[ ] Formatting is consistent — one font, one heading style, page numbers on every page after the title page.

[ ] The report has been proofread, ideally aloud, and read once more from the reader's point of view.

Chapter 12: Conclusion

A business report is a practical document with a practical purpose: to give a reader the information and the judgement they need to make a decision. This report has shown that good report writing is not a matter of talent or of long words, but of method. The method has a clear order: agree the purpose and the questions before starting; gather information honestly and describe how it was gathered; present findings in order, with tables and charts that support the text; analyse the findings with tools such as SWOT analysis, market comparison and simple financial reasoning; draw conclusions that follow from the evidence; and make recommendations that a real person can carry out by a real date. Around that method sit the habits that make a report professional: a standard structure, a summary written last, clear and concise sentences, consistent formatting, honest acknowledgement of limitations, and careful proofreading.

The worked examples in this report — the fictional Ravi General Store and the fictional Ayesha's Bakery — show that the same method works for a small shop and for a new product, and that it works at a small scale as well as a large one. A student writing a first report and a manager writing a report for a board of directors are doing the same thing: turning evidence into a decision. The reader who follows the structure in Chapter 3, the summary guidance in Chapter 4, the analysis tools in Chapter 7, and the checklist in Chapter 11 will be able to write a report that a busy

reader can use — and that, in the end, is the only test that matters. A report is finished not when the writer has said everything they know, but when the reader knows what to do next.

Suggested Reading

The books and guides below are well-known general works on business writing, report writing and research methods. They are listed as starting points for further reading; a reader should use the edition available in their own library and check their institution's own guidance on referencing and report format, which takes precedence over any general guide.

- General guides to business communication and business writing — standard textbooks on business communication cover report structure, memoranda, proposals and presentations, and are a good first reference for any report writer.
- Guides to academic and report writing — books on writing essays, reports and dissertations explain structure, referencing, and the difference between description, analysis and argument.
- Research methods texts — introductory books on business research methods explain surveys, interviews, sampling and the presentation of data, and are useful for the methodology and findings chapters.
- Books on plain English and clear writing — guides to plain English give practical rules for short sentences, active voice and the removal of jargon, and repay regular use.
- Company annual reports and published market-research reports — freely available on company and government websites, these are real examples of professional reporting and are the best models for layout, tables and executive summaries.
- Style guides published by universities and professional bodies — most universities publish a guide to report writing and referencing for their students; use the guide of your own institution where one exists.

A note on sources: this report does not list specific authors and years for individual claims, because invented citations would mislead the reader. When writing a real report, every source actually consulted must be listed with full publication details, and every quotation or figure taken from a source must be cited at the point where it is used.